

Lumia battery fix

Nokia rolling out battery issue fix for Lumia 800 smartphone

ICS Zooms in

Motorola has begun rolling out ICS update for Xoom tablets in the U.S.

High-end smartphones

phones in some cases. So let's begin with the first category.

₹20,000 and ₹29,999

Kicking things off is the BlackBerry Curve 9380. The touch-screen-only form factor comes to the Curve series, looking a lot like the younger cousin of the much more expensive Torch 9860. Despite not being the most powerful of the lot, with an 806MHz processor, the Curve doesn't disappoint as far as the overall system performance is concerned. Apps open smoothly, and it only feels a bit of a strain when you have more than five apps open in the background. It is possibly one of the better-built smartphones, which feels a lot more expensive than it actually is. Great for the customer.



BlackBerry Curve 9380

The Nokia X7 is a phone from the future, at least it looks like that. It has an edgy design, but fails to impress past that. Having

said that, we must say that the fault isn't the hardware per se, but the dated Symbian OS. If you still like the old school charm and would stick with Symbian, the performance offered by the X7 isn't bad. Or you could just buy the N8 for a little bit more money. Not only do you get a fabulous 12MP camera, but a build quality that's equally brilliant if not this futuristic. The Symbian Anna update did wonders to the N8 performance package. While the X7 has a bigger display, the N8's 3.5-inch display isn't uncomfortable to use in any way. But there's no getting away from the fact

that the OS isn't slick and feels considerably dated, both in UI and architecture.

The phone we're about to pick up next, the Sony Ericsson Xperia Play, has been around for some time now. However, there still isn't a phone around that looks quite like this, or offers the experience the Play does. Lovingly known as the PlayStation phone in the days prior to its offi-



Nokia N7

HOW WE TESTED

The smartphone is an extremely interesting device category to test, not only because of the diversity (hardware, operating systems, customisations, feature sets, etc.) but also because it seems to be the most vibrant – as in, the sheer pace at which new phones, OS updates and hardware arrives in the market. The traditional estimate that a phone normally lasts 1 year before falling into the outdated category doesn't hold true anymore.

To test the smartphones that we had on our desk, there was a similar amount of diverse testing required at our end before we could really adjudge a winner.

Benchmarks

First off, we ran a series of benchmarks to get a set of numbers allowing us to directly compare the performance of all the devices – processor, graphics, storage and even the web browser. Each platform largely has its own set of benchmarks, with only the PeaceKeeper Browser benchmark being truly cross platform. We have given equal weightage to all benchmark scores, so as to not put the other platforms at a disadvantage. We ran benchmarks on Android (Quadrant, AnTuTu, LinPack and GLBenchmark), iOS (Linpack

and GLBenchmark), Windows Phone 7.5 (WP Bench and MultiBench) and the cross platform Peacekeeper benchmark.

Call quality was tested on all phones in three different signal zones – full signal, 50 per cent signal and very low signal, usually 1-2 bars. Points are reduced for every call drop, voice echo and audio break situations and also when audio is completely lost but the call isn't dropped.

The built-in speaker was scored on the clarity and loudness parameters, both for calls and multimedia playback. The video playback test, also a part of the multimedia test, was a combination of the display quality (brightness, colour depth, sharpness and black level depth) and the processor/RAM's ability to play back the video files smoothly. In all of these being high-end smartphones, the power package was never the bottleneck in video playback, which laid the emphasis more on the doorstep of the display.

Battery life

The battery life test on all the smartphones was done to see how long the phone lasts on a single charge, from full charge to full discharge. The usage included video playback, web browsing and IM chats, quite a bit of gaming and some voice calls, all with either 3G or Wi-Fi connected throughout.

Included features

The hardware package does have considerable amount of weightage to it. More points are given to dual-core processors. Every display type has been allocated a preset number of points to it, and the phones were scored according to those guidelines. The camera gets points for the mega-pixel numbers, as well as additional features such as HDR, image stabilisation, video stabilisation and 3D Panorama Shot. Camera performance is rated on the basis of the quality of pictures and video – clarity, sharpness, noise (or the lack of it), colour depth, fast motion fluidity and the amount of tweaking the settings options offer.

OS Matters

We believe that the OS does have a huge bearing on the overall package that a smartphone offers – performance, apps, tariff etc. For example- most apps (WhatsApp, Facebook etc.) on BlackBerry won't work if you don't have a full Internet BlackBerry plan activated. However, there are no such limitations on the other platforms. There are a lot of other factors attached to an OS – app ecosystem, amount of customization possible, the features and tweaks possible all have a bearing on this rating. ■